religious instruction into a more formal and expanded course of education. At the primary level, students were taught reading, writing, medicine, history, and accountancy. Children were not required to spend too much time practising the alphabet but instead began to learn Persian couplets and moral phrases so that they instinctively learnt the texture and nuance of the language. At the middle level, ‘secular’ themes like logic, arithmetic, astronomy, accountancy, and agriculture were introduced which encouraged a large number of Hindus, Kayasthas, and Khichri especially, to join madrasas in large numbers, beginning with the village schools, or maktabs, so as to have a coveted career in the imperial Mughal service. In maktabs, which children joined at the age of four, Kayastha children were taught accounting skills and would grow up to serve as land registrars and village accountants while the more accomplished ones became news writers, revenue reporters, petition writers, and court readers. The maktab curriculum included classics from Persian literature such as Sa’di’s *Gulistan* and Firdausi’s *Shahnama* and the Kayastha clans became increasingly ‘Persianized’, even acquiring Persian pen names.

By the middle of the seventeenth century, the departments of accountancy, draftsmanship, and the office of the revenue minister were mostly filled by Hindu munshis, and Chandra Bhan ‘Brahman’ would be rated second only to Abu’l Fazl in his prose and poetry. ‘A man who knows how to write good prose as well as accountancy is a bright light even among lights,’ wrote Chandra Bhan in a letter, giving refreshingly timeless advice to his son about being a Mughal munshi. ‘Besides, a munshi should be discreet and virtuous.’ Through Persian, Akbar sought to unite the far-flung inhabitants of his empire, polyphonic and multi-faith, beyond the divisive binary of religion. This meant that a certain intangible Mughal essence, the tehzeeb, a refinement of language, manners and morals, spread outwards from Fatehpur Sikri like a flood tide to the distant corners of the empire.

Persian intellectuals, thinkers, and poets were drawn to Akbar’s inclusive court in a steady stream during the 1580s. By the late sixteenth and early seventeenth century, this would become a deluge. Historian Sunil Sharma uses the example of a French traveller, Jean Chardin, who described this situation with sweeping generalizations in 1666, to illustrate an exodus of talented Persian families from the Iranian plateau towards Hindustan: